

DESIGN FOR REAL PEOPLE

Playbook



Royal College of Art

Imperial College
London

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Version 1.0

This playbook is a live resource to accompany the Design for real people (DRP) program.

DRP

INTRO



About this playbook

This Playbook is a tool to support you on your research and design journey.

The four stages can offer guidance from starting your research process to delivering your final project solution.

The templates/tools are suggestions for ways of working, but you can develop your own that are best suited to your project's needs.

An approach that puts people's needs and what they value at the centre of your innovation process.

Examines people's lives and what they actually do and what they do it to generate new value for them.

**SERVICES AND
PRODUCTS ARE
DESIGNED TO DO
A JOB THAT
SOMEONE NEEDS**

Your project: what's it about

Milestone 0

Milestone 0 : pre-pitch project framing

“Getting off to a good Start. What is your project about and why does it Matter?”

We recommend that you choose a project area that you’re inspired by, passionate about and where you have access to the people involved!

As a group, in order to help you prepare for the Milestone 1 elevator pitch, you should capture your initial framing of your chosen scenario in the form of a written project proposal of no more than one side of A4.

The following narrative should help your group to define, develop and frame your project to present a convincing pitch:

Milestone 0 : pre-pitch project framing

The context and knowledge base - Your area of interest and focus e.g. food charity (the place, the people, the story). What knowledge and expertise do you have to successfully work on this project? What access to users/stakeholders do you have to test and develop ideas? What potential ideas and resources do you have that will help you develop a meaningful digital touchpoint?

The people - i.e. specific details around your target audience and other stakeholders in the context who are connected in some way to the challenge area e.g. food charity worker, volunteers in the system etc. The richer and more detailed the personas presented, the better.

Evidence - tangible “data” that you have gathered that is the basis for your project. Data in design terms is more qualitative, preferably, first-hand sources- think people, not numbers. This type of data leads to authentic and rich insights and analysis and usually only requires working with a few, well-chosen people who are relevant to the context being explored

Insight and analysis - the specific observations and meaning drawn from the evidence - the key statements and research you have done based on your data. The people you’re designing for are usually not consciously aware of these until you present your analysis to them.

Milestone 0 : pre-pitch project framing

Challenge Statement - what's your challenge statement based on the above evidence e.g.,

“Hundreds of thousands of tonnes of good food is wasted by the UK food industry every year. At the same time, millions of people are struggling to afford to eat. This food charity addresses these 2 issues by redistributing food industry surplus which would otherwise go to waste, to the people who need it most. Volunteers are key in helping to distribute food to charities. However, project managers are struggling to effectively manage the supply and demand of these volunteers.”

Opportunity Statement - a succinct description of the challenge you will address.

E.g. *“How Might We... enable food charity project managers to strengthen and efficiently organise their volunteers in order to create a vibrant and reliable volunteer network whilst reaching increasing numbers of people in need”* Some early ideas may emerge from this towards a digital touchpoint.

Design your research

After discussing your topics as a group, and exploring the who, what, when etc, you should now have a list of topics for desk research, a stakeholder map, a plan of how to contact stakeholders for interviews, a list of places to visit and some processes you would like to observe. You can be as creative as you like with your research methods.

Design starts at this stage, design your research. Think about the best ways to engage your participants. What tasks could you ask them to do that would give insight?

Design your questions - What you need to understand that you currently do not?

Design your method - in person zoom, what preparation do you want to give the interview participants?

Design your tools - in person paper conversational tools, or online Miro or Figma versions? Is there any information you would like participants to send? Would like to see your participants perform certain tasks? What is the best way to find out in-depth information?

Design your research library = How are you storing and sharing your data? How will you make it easy to access when designing?

Remember: Design research is about finding out information that will inform your design. Keep asking yourself when conducting research 'do you have enough information to design with? Can you make informed decisions? Or am I still guessing?' You can change your interview questions in the moment to gain greater understanding. It can open up new research avenues in your desk research.

Desktop research

Statistics - academic papers, commercial studies and consumer insights reports.

Competitor analysis - what is the current best practice in the space you are aiming to design for? Where are the gaps?

Blogs, social media, forums - indirect user insights. People discussing their experiences and opinions.

Use desk research whilst you are waiting to organise user interviews, start immediately

Desktop research can progress your thinking around a subject and enable you to ask more insightful questions in your interviews

Desk research can provide qualitative data to combine with your quantitative data for richer insights.

Field research

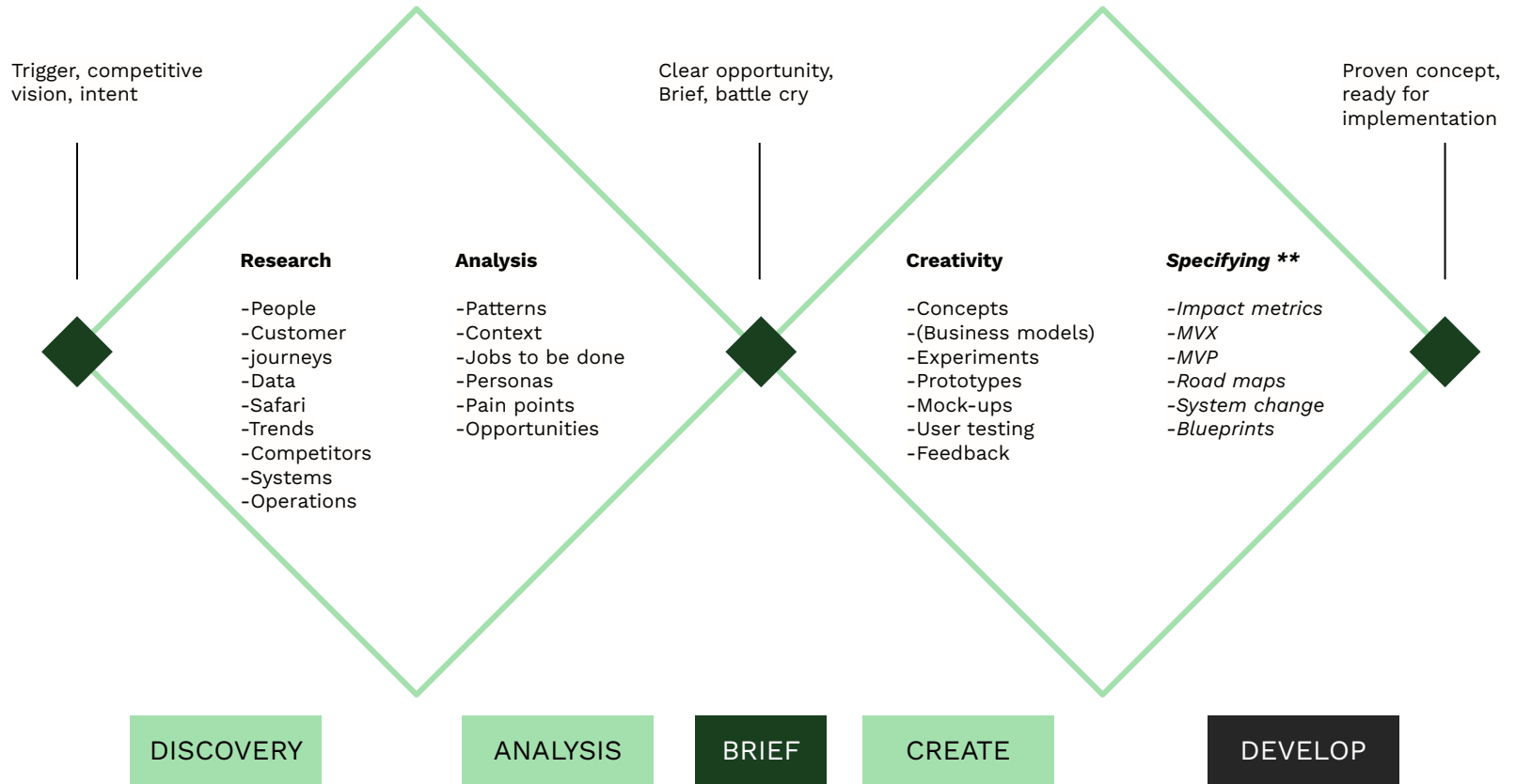
User interviews - Interviews with stakeholders. Asking questions to gain direct insight into how people feel. Can be in person or online.

Observations - observe people, interactions, decisions. See what people actually do and compare with what they say.

Walk throughs - experience the whole product/service journey yourself. Try and experience it from the perspective of your stakeholders.

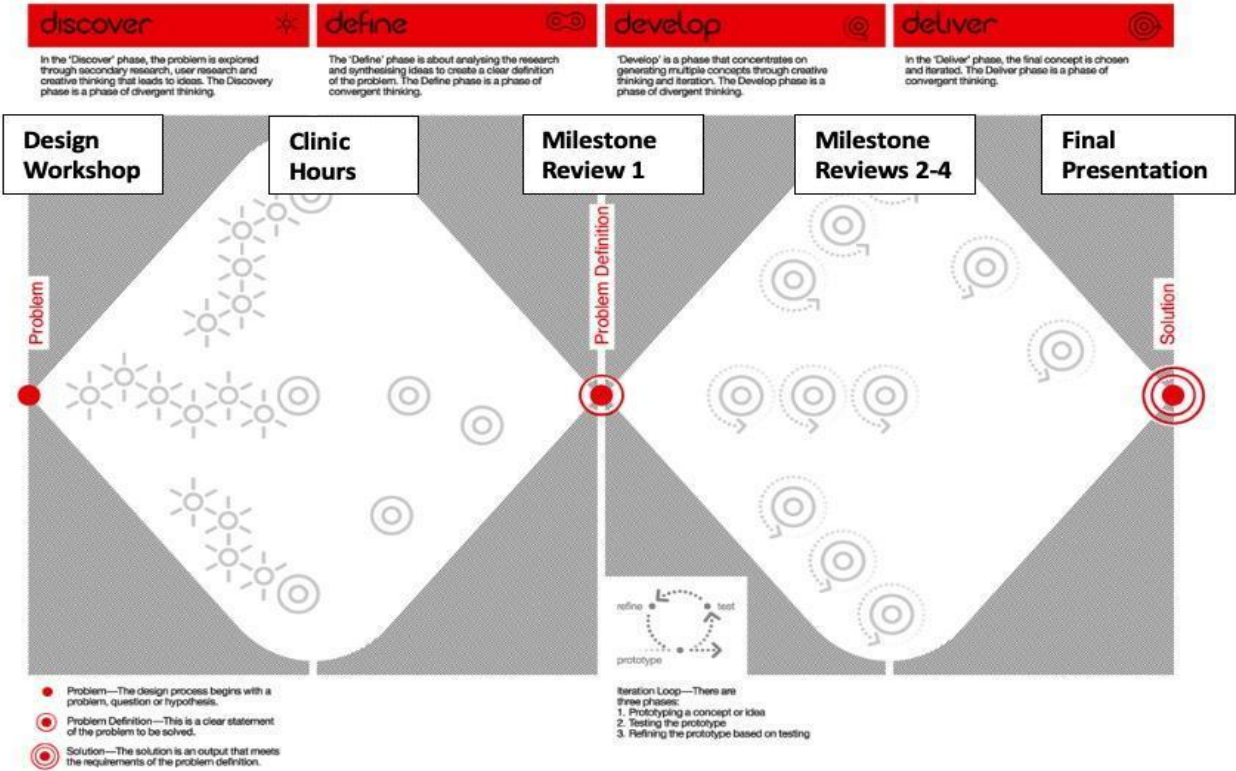
Field research is essential. It allows you to gain in-depth understanding of the experiences of different stakeholders.

It also allows you, the researcher to observe processes and decisions first-hand, objectively.



*Not required for the
DRP project**

DOUBLE DIAMOND IN DRP



DISCOVER



Get to know your users, understand their contexts and the challenges they face. This can be done through interviews, workshops, through asking them to use early stage prototypes, or simply conversations. Really listen to what they have to tell you. They are the expert in their situation. Gain consent for their participation and documentation in your project.

Who are they? What do you know about them? What do you know about what they are trying to do? What challenges are they facing? Why is it a problem for them? What are their needs? How are they currently managing this issue?



PLAN YOUR RESEARCH - user interview

The overall aim of a user interview is to gain deeper understanding of a person's experience of a situation.

Tips

- Introduce yourself and the project
- Provide a warm welcome. Explain there are no right or wrong answers.
- Breathe and practice active listening.
- Ask interviewees about specific moments in the past, not imaginary moments in the future.
This is often best achieved with a conversational prompt tool.
- Ask open-ended questions.
- Ask follow-up questions such as why

Before the interview

Plan your questions, be clear about which areas you are looking to find out about. Design your questions so they are actually answerable. Test the interview questions on friends and iterate if needed. Plan how you will record responses and share with the group.

During the interview

Keep the conversation on topic. Keep thinking, do I understand well enough to design with the information in that answer? If not, ask more questions to understand.

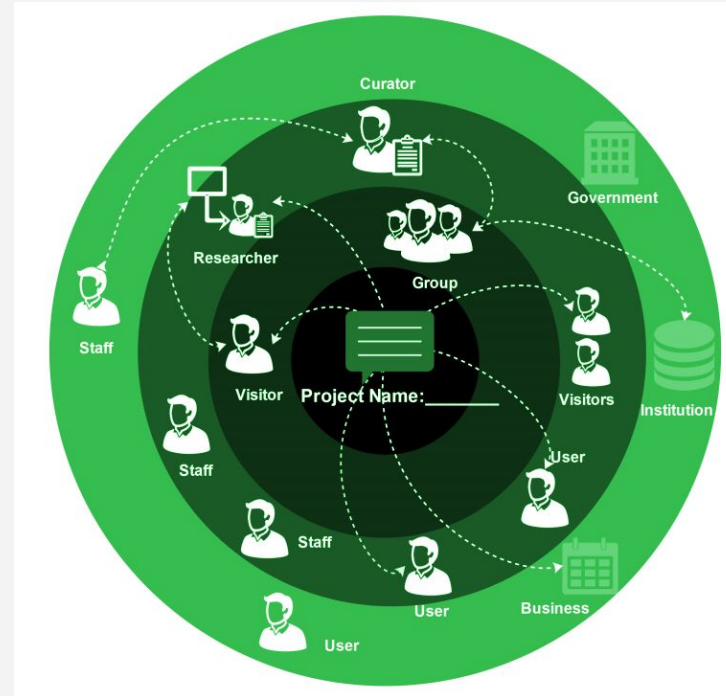
After the interview

Write down the key takeaways immediately after the interview.

Process the interview into useful quotes that are in an accessible, shareable format.

Who is in the cast of your film?
Creating a map of all the characters you think have a role to play. Map who is central, who is less so, the relationships between them and their contexts. This might change as your research progresses and your project is more informed by the evidence you gather, so be ready to come back to this and iterate.

Map out who is part of your ecosystem. From the most important center to the indirect outer rings. Define the relationships between stakeholders and understand how they interact and why



When you have developed a strong understanding of your key character's needs and their contexts, you can create personas that capture the key insights and criteria you need to keep in mind as you work.

Persona

2

Who?	Needs / Pains	Goals / Motivations
 Name: Gender: Age: Interests? Dreams? Where does he/she lives? How is his/her daily life? Knowledge? Skills?	Jobs to be done?	What are the benefits he/she is looking for?

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When you have understood more about your key character and other cast members and their situations through first-hand research, try to map what you have learnt about their experiences. What does this tell you about the challenges they face and what support would benefit them?

Empathy Map



A customer journey map describes each stage of a process a person (customer, citizen) goes through during their experience of the product or service.

Map how the customer is experiencing the product or service in the context you have defined.

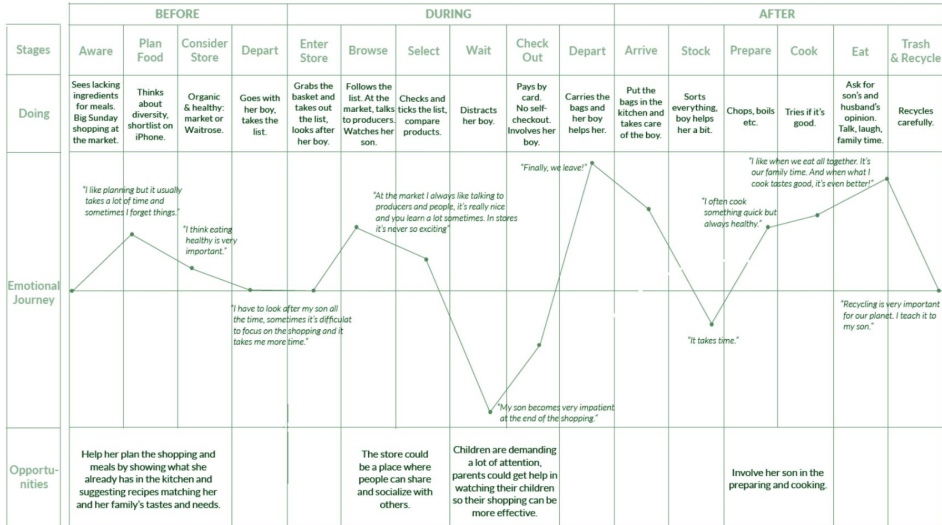
Map out the journey over time and capture the key moments across all channels of delivery.

What is your key character currently experiencing in the context you're focusing on?

Journeys

Julia, 34
Mother of 8 year-old son
& housewife

"I like going to the market, because there I can talk to the producers."

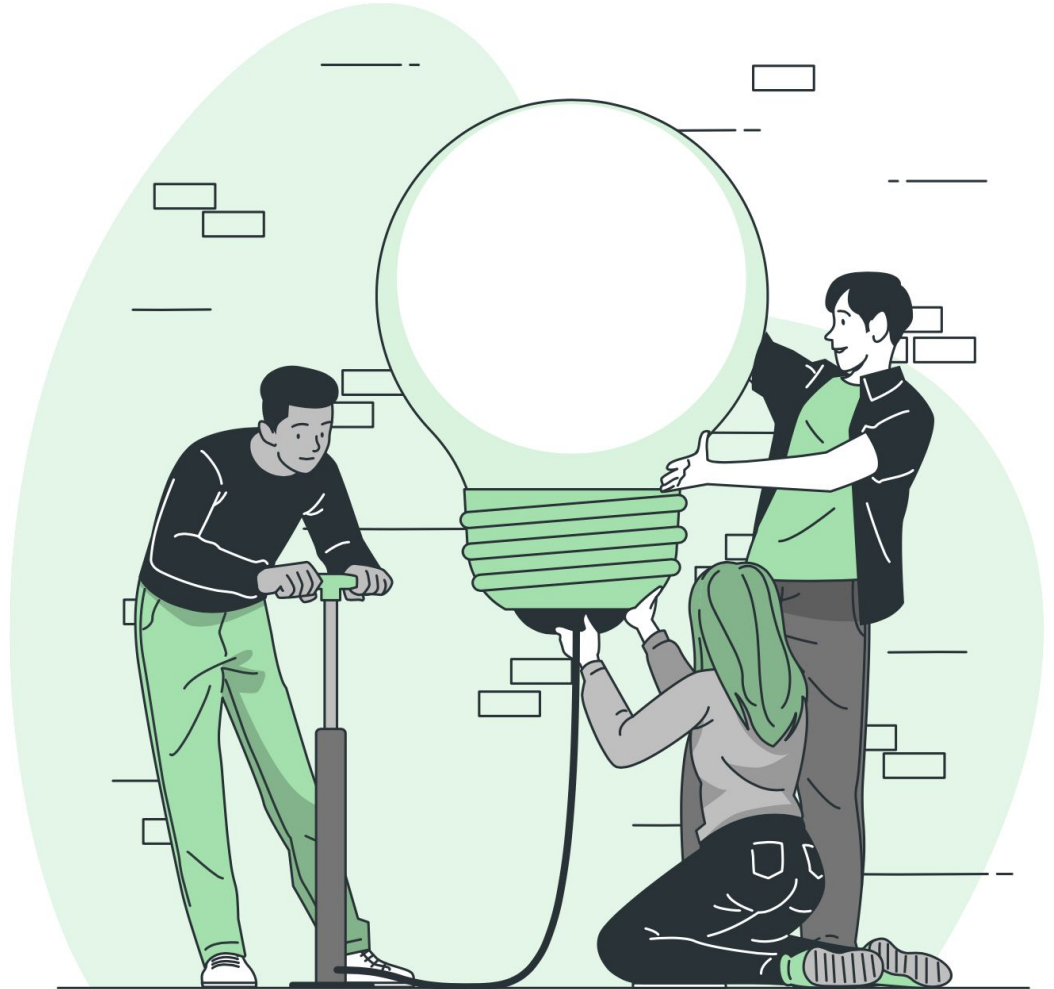


Gather insights

The Discover stage is the beginning of your research process. You can liken your project's journey to creating a film. People are at the heart of the action. To start, ask yourself who is your cast of characters? What situations are they currently in? What are their relationships? How do they interact and what challenges do they face? And who is the leading character in your story? While you may have some ideas about the answers to these questions now, these are your hypotheses that should be validated through your research process in this stage of work.

In Discover phase you want to expand your research, exploring a wide range of areas to ensure you see the full picture. Speak to people, ask questions about their situation, what do they already do to solve their problems? Who supports them? What tools do they use? Document this as you go and gain consent from your participants.

DEFINE



Define the right problem

With broad, exploratory research undertaken, the Define stage is where you can synthesise what you have found, ask what it means for your project and the problem/s you want to solve. What did you find in your initial research? What surprised you? What was as you expected? Is the leading character still who you thought it would be? Are the relationships between people the same as you thought or different? Map these things out.

Identify the complexities of the situations, the relationships between people, the timeline of events and where the challenges lie. Look at the quotes from the people you have spoken to, identify the pain points in the empathy maps you have created. Be clear about the issues the different characters face. From all of this work, the objective of this stage is to find the key issue your project needs to address and to be able to define the problem you are going to solve.

Process your research. Synthesise your observations and all of the information you gathered. Find the core problems. Focus down to a key problem to solve.

Do not start this phase unless you have found out new and surprising things about your topic. If you only have observations that you could have predicted before conducting the research, go back, find out more.

INSIGHTS - Post-it note Affinity mapping method

Affinity Diagram: Affinity mapping helps process your interviews, sort your findings, and identify insights in your data.

Step 1: Gather all of your data in one place and write down all research / facts / thoughts / ideas on the topic onto the post-it notes.

Step 2: You will find some post-it notes that are similar to each other or on the same topic. Combine them together.

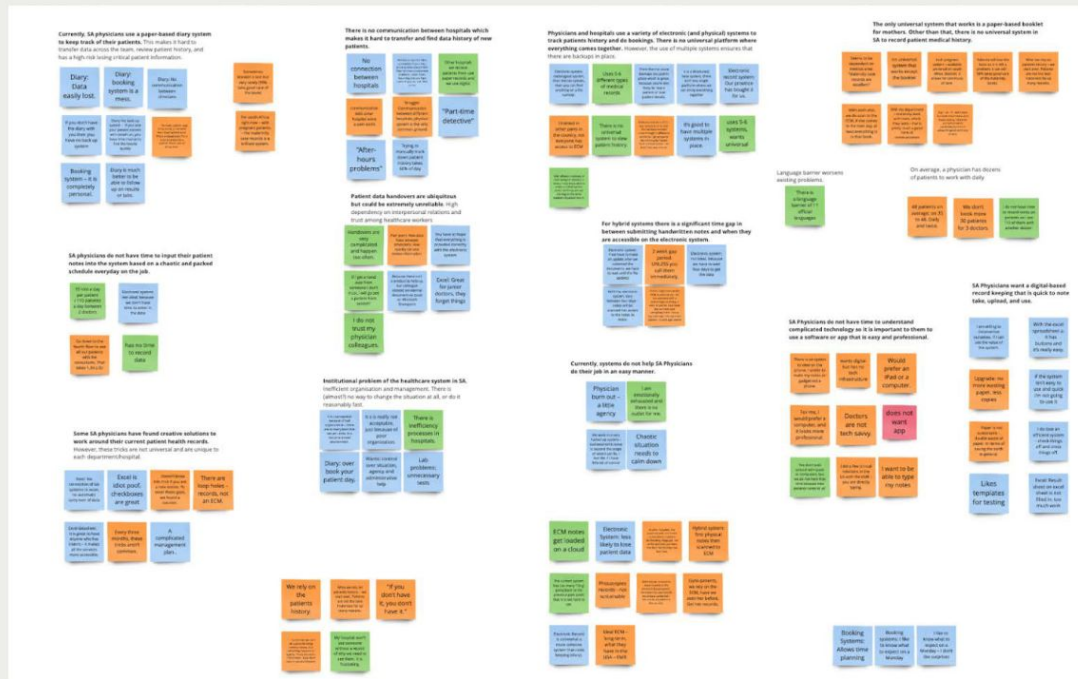
Step 3: Summarise each category in one sentence statements.



INSIGHTS - Post-it note Affinity mapping method

Step 4: After your interviews, put down a fact from the research (whether thought, opinion, interesting fact) on a post-it note).

Step 5: Then cluster the post-it notes in categories where they are similar. This will reveal user insights and themes of your research.



INSIGHTS - Post-it note Affinity mapping method

Step 6: Afterwards, build a 1 sentence statement of the cluster so we understand the insight.



Currently, SA physicians use a paper-based diary system to keep track of their patients. This makes it hard to transfer data across the team, review patient history, and has a high-risk losing critical patient information.

Diary:
Data
easily lost.

Diary:
booking
system is a
mess.

Diary: No
communication
between
clinicians

Sometimes
booklet is lost but
very rarely (99%
take good care of
the book)

If you don't have
the diary with
you then you
have no back up
system

Diary: No back up
system - If you lose
your patient stickers
with details on, you
have little chance to
find the results
quickly

- We make a photo copy
of my notes, or we write
her a short referral note.
This is a repeat scan. Put it
in an envelope for a
patient. Those sort of
things help.

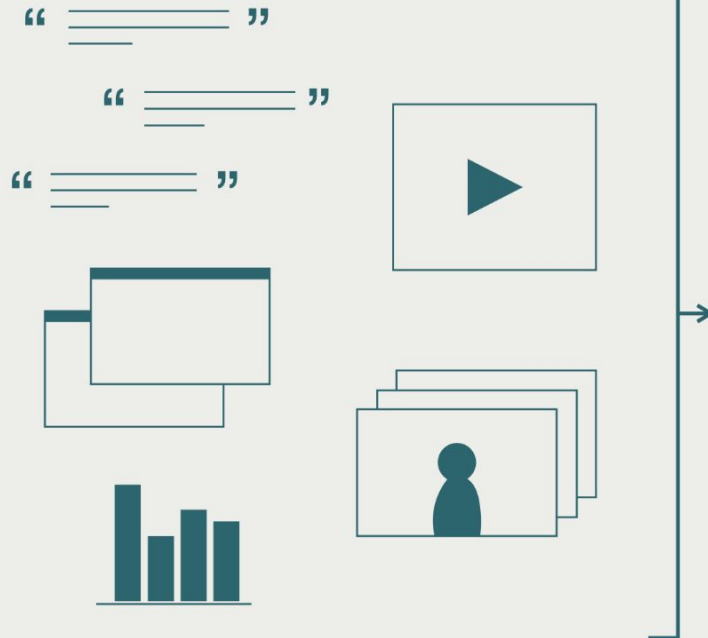
For south Africa
right now - with
pregnant patients
- the maternity
case records is a
brilliant system.

Booking
system - it is
completely
personal.

Diary is much
better to be
able to follow
up on results
or tabs.

INSIGHTS - Multimedia Miro/Figma

By using online collaboration tools like Miro, it is possible to build up multimedia insights incorporating, photos and videos and links to web pages with you quotes. You can use the affinity mapping Post-it method to analyse, and then present all the data associated to make sure you have not mis-analysed any of it.



INSIGHT

Headline

Description

What is the broader insight, why do you think this?

Observations

What have you seen or heard that led you to this insight?

Implications and opportunities

what does this mean and what could you do to solve the problem/ enhance the interaction. Is there a design brief?



When you have a deep understanding of your characters, you should be able to write stories for them, to succinctly summarise what those needs are in the context of your project.

What do the characters need to do, who do they do it?

User story

3⁷²

As a **<customer type>**
I want **<do something>**
so I can **<get some benefit>**.

As a **<commuter>** I want **<to see all routes I could travel to location>**, so I can **<choose the route that gets me their the quickest>**.



How might we” is a trigger to define concepts around the jobs to be done and user stories. By answering the question HMW you can generate many different types fo solution or features that solve the need and provide different ways to add value to your stakeholders.

How Might We...?

HMW:

Create multiple
patient profiles

HMW:

Keep the
layout simple?

HMW:

Use autofill
to reduce
repetition?

Articulating the problem you want to solve can help you focus on the goal of your project. Be clear and succinct, and keep in mind who is involved in the contexts.

How might we... help users commute in London in an easy way... through giving different alternatives combining maps & means of transport?

Weeks 2-4

DEVELOP

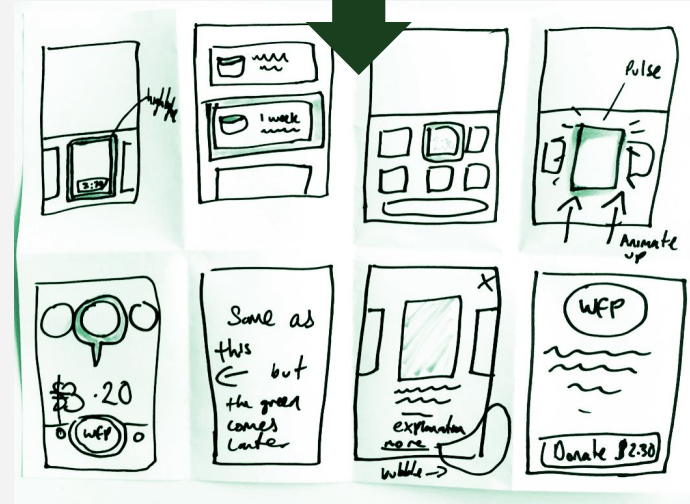
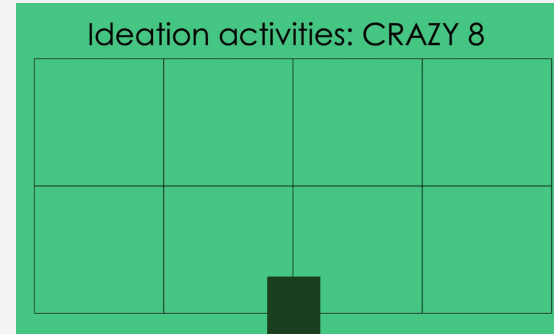


Ideation with the key stakeholders... “how might we?” and prototype and test

Once you have clearly defined the problem you are going to solve and you understand the contexts your characters are operating within, as well as the relationships between them, where they currently find support and what their challenges are, you are ready to begin developing solutions. In this stage of work, develop many different ideas for ways you can address your characters' problems. Prototype, test your designs with users, gather feedback and document the results. Learn from your findings and prototype again.

Prototyping here can take many different forms and should support you to explore a range of design directions. In this module, you need to deliver a digital touchpoint, but this may be just one part of your solution and user's journey. Remember that there can be a range of other design touchpoints, interactions and settings involved in your project, and think about how they work together to solve your users' challenges.

Begin by developing a range of different design ideas. Once you have drawn or written 8 or more, look back at what you have produced and think through their strengths and weaknesses to help you decide which to explore further.

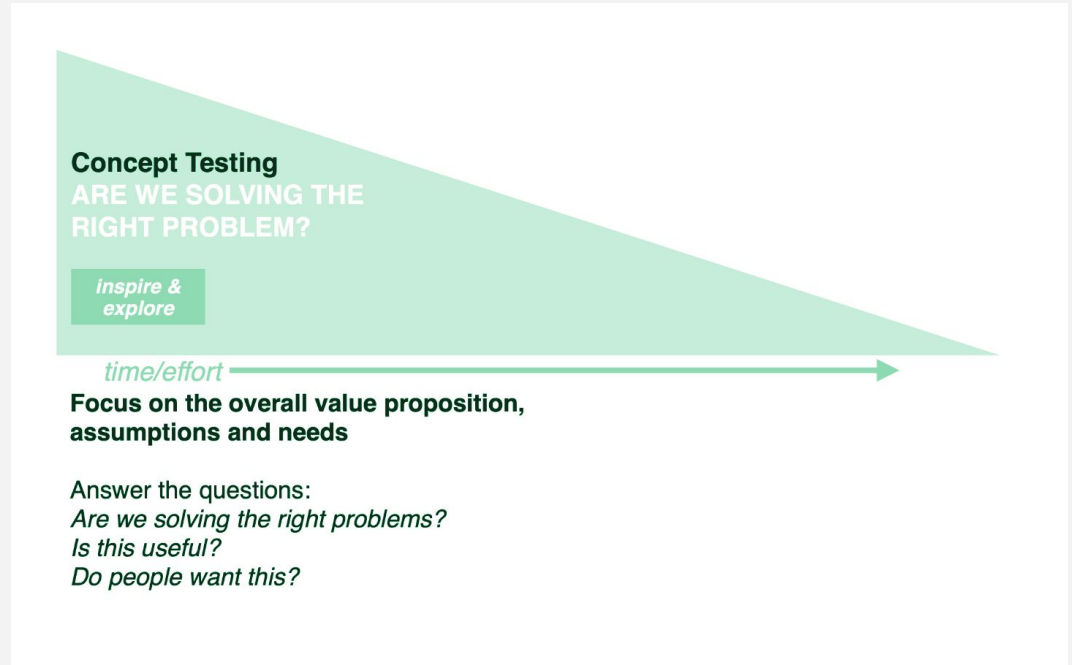


Design from minimum viable pilot to minimum viable product

Once you have prototyped and tested a wide range of design directions and options, and you can start to see which ones best support your characters and help them to overcome their challenges, you can move into focusing on how you deliver your solution. Here you can go into greater detail in the design specifics, creating higher fidelity prototypes and testing the nuances of the way you might deliver your solution.

As with all stages, keep testing and iterating as you go so that you have confidence that your design works for your main character and can be supported by the wider cast. By the end of the module, you should be able to demonstrate that real people have engaged with your digital touchpoint, that you have captured insights and deep engagement, that you have acted on the feedback you have received, and that you can offer a seamless user experience.

Concept testing can be a useful way of ensuring you are focusing on the right problem and that the design directions you are exploring will support that.



Storyboarding can allow you to map the design from the user's experience, including the different stages of the journey, the touchpoint and how it feels for the user.

Storyboards can let you test the overall value proposition, organizing the order of experience and the jobs to be done.



1) Aaron wakes up bright and early, checking his phone for new e-mails and taking a look at what his day will look like.



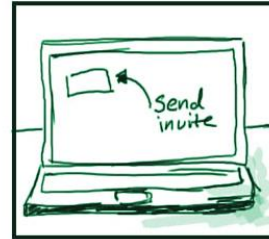
2) He sees that he has several client meetings, followed by time to get work done, an Excelsior marketing meeting and a T-ball game for his daughter. Okay, not too crazy.



3) He sees that the first meeting is in a part of town he is not familiar with. Fortunately his calendar can link to the GPS driving directions app on his phone.



4) After the meeting Aaron gets to work, while he is doing that he remembers that he wanted Dianne to be at the Excelsior marketing meeting.



5) He forwards the meeting invite to her.



6) During lunch when Aaron is reading on his tablet his wife calls. They plan set up a date night the next Friday.

Prototyping can take many different forms and should begin with early-stage, low fidelity mockups that can be used in user testing to understand if an idea will support the user in the way you hope. Learn from your findings, prototype again and keep iterating.

It is about how people solve a problem in the context of a user journey.



Prototyping requires planning:

What do you want to learn or test?

What is the best way to do that?

With whom should you share?

In what context should you test?

Where and with which medium?

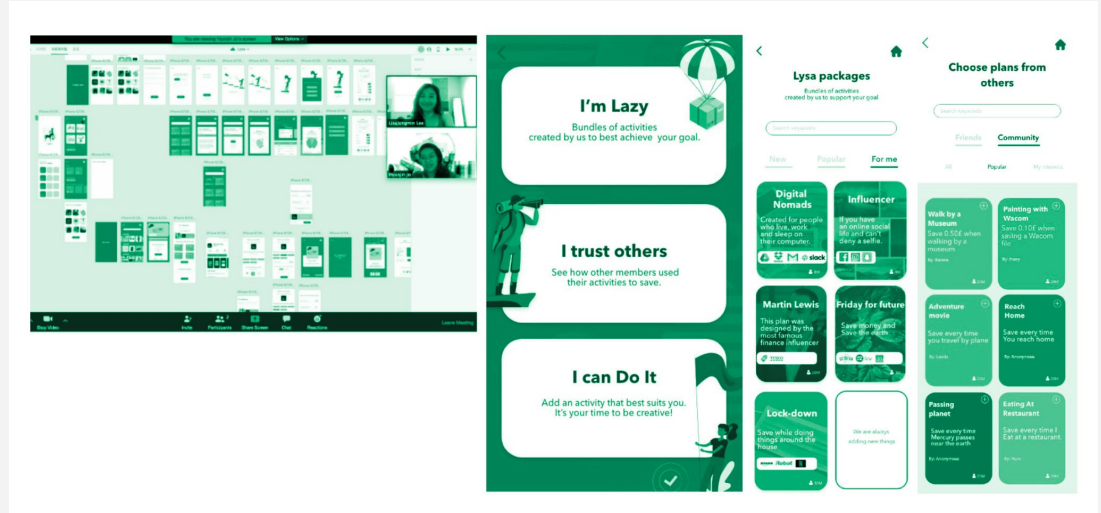
What type is appropriate?

How will you record feedback?



Paper prototypes and clickable interactions can test mental models, user flows, priorities, preferences and general usability.

Decide your format for the right stage of your design process: from paper prototypes to high fidelity digital screens to physical models or communications mockups.



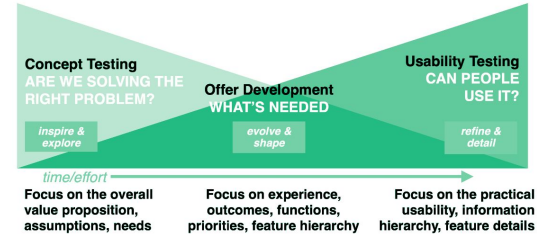
Three stages:

1 - At the right scale

2 - Shape the offer

3 - Focus on details

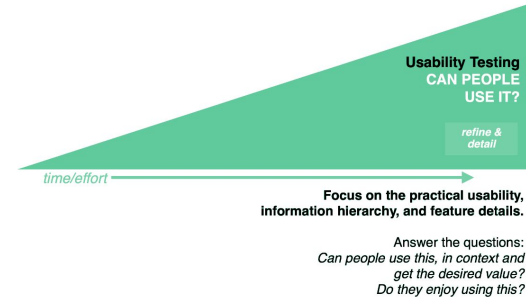
1



2



3



Learn what they are thinking; don;t tell them what to think!

1. Let users know their opinion is valuable, and you want honest feedback. You can present yourself as the 'researcher' not the 'designer' in order to create distance.
2. Start your session with a chat. Get to know them a bit; their background can help you understand their biases or experiences relevant to your idea.
3. Give them just enough info to set the context, do not sell your idea.
4. Give them time to review, then ask how they feel about it, and what they would change.



Learn what they are thinking; don't tell them what to think!

1. If you are testing, share a link before your session so they can navigate themselves if remote.
2. Ask them to 'Share their screen' via your video conferencing tool.
3. Observe how they navigate without guiding them.
4. Ask them to "think ahead" and narrate as they explore, as you can see what they are thinking
5. Between each step, stop and ask them what they expect before they move on



STORYTELLING

**A SELECTION OF STORYTELLING
WORKSHEETS TO HELP YOU IDEATE,
STRUCTURE AND CRAFT YOUR
AMAZING STORY.**

CLARITY

YOUR AUDIENCE

Know who you are talking to, what is expected and how you can engage them

**WHO ARE
THEY?**

your friends, business leaders,
investors, your team?

**WHY SHOULD
THEY CARE?**

You key points of difference,
benefits and impact

VALUE PROPOSITION

Your value proposition details what you offer customers and why they should choose you

WE ARE a subscription service

FOR new renters

SO THEY find their community

BECAUSE deeper connection

SUPER POWERS

Describe your unique selling points to differentiate your idea

What are its super powers?	What makes it unique?	What makes it different?

USP 1

USP 2

USP 3

THREE WORD STORY

Define the essence of your story

My idea

Example:

A subscription service
for new renters to find,
share and connect
to their local community

My Story

FIND
MY
TRIBE

THE DEMO

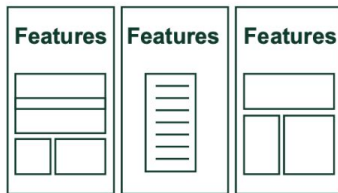
Remember: Start with context and the user problem then introduce your idea, ux flow and features

1



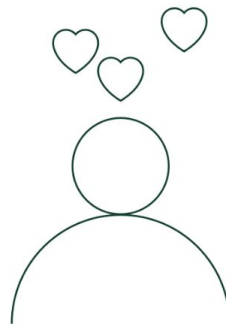
CONCEPT

2



FEATURES

3



BENEFITS

STRUCTURE

THREE ACTS

Think about your narrative and key story points

Start

What is the
problem

Middle

How you
solve it

End

The impact
created

WWWH

Describe your story by answering why, who, what and how.

WHY	WHO	WHAT	HOW
Describe your problem	Describe your user	Describe your concept	Describe how it works
CONTEXT	USER	CONCEPT	SYSTEM

STRATEGY

Describe your product/service strategy by filling out the boxes

1. The problem

2. The fix

3.The features

4. The benefits

LADDER

Use the ladder to structure your story content

CONTEXT	PROBLEM	RESEARCH	PROTOTYPE	OUTCOME

STYLE

STORY STYLE

Check you have your story elements



STARTERS

Think about how you want to start your story. Here are some examples...

Anecdote

My mother use
to spend all her
time doing X

Imagine

What would happen
if you got married
to AI?

Connection

We all find taxes
boring and hard
to do...

What if...

We could make
privacy automatic
and easy?

Data

There are 94%
of people without
power

Drama

We have to change
before its too late

THE HOOK

Start with a strong opening to get your audience hooked, it should be memorable, meaningful and engaging.

EXAMPLE

The world is ending...
(drama)

Abby has a problem...
Personal

95% people hate icecream
(statistics)

Many of us are depressed
(emotion)

QUALITIES

DRAMATIC

PERSONAL

EMOTIONAL

ALARMING

INSIGHTFUL

HOPE

MISSING

MY HOOK?

WOW MOMENT

Describe your wow moment

WHAT

WOW

1 — PITCH DECK

1. CONTEXT

WHAT IS THE SETTING,
WHAT'S HAPPENING, OTHER
FACTS

SETTING

2. PROBLEM

WHAT IS THE PROBLEM
YOU ARE SOLVING?

OPPORTUNITY

3. AUDIENCE

WHO IS EXPERIENCING THE
PROBLEM? WHAT ARE THEIR
ISSUES? WHO ELSE IS
INVOLVED?

USER(S)

4. GOALS AND IMPACT

WHAT NEEDS ARE YOU
SOLVING FOR

MISSION

5. VALUE

WHAT WILL THE KEY
BENEFITS BE TO SOLVE
THE ISSUE?

IMPACT

5. PLAN

WHAT ARE YOU PLANNING
TO DO NEXT?

ACTION

2 — PRESENTATION

1. CONTEXT

WHAT IS
YOUR TOPIC?

INTRO

2. PROBLEM

WHAT IS THE PROBLEM
YOU ARE SOLVING?

DATA

3. AUDIENCE

WHO IT IS FOR AND WHAT
ARE THEIR ISSUES?

PERSONA

5. OPPORTUNITY

WHAT KEY INSIGHTS
FROM RESEARCH?

RESEARCH

6. PROPOSITION

WHAT IS YOUR IDEA AND
HOW DOES IT WORK?

DEMO

7. VALUE

WHAT ARE THE BENEFITS
AND IMPACT?

FEATURES

8. TESTING

WHAT HAVE YOU LEARNT?
HOW HAVE YOU DEVELOPED
YOUR IDEA?

VALIDATION

9. CONCLUSION

WHAT WENT WELL?
BENEFITS? FUTURE WORK

EVALUATION

END